nature of the singularity in which quantum physics and spacetime curvature would be married.

Neither name was satisfactory. Neither paid particular attention to the horizon which surrounds the collapsed star and which is responsible for the optical illusion of stellar "freezing." During the 1960s, physicists' calculations gradually revealed the enormous importance of the horizon, and gradually John Wheeler—the person who, more than anyone else, worries about using optimal names—became more and more dissatisfied.

It is Wheeler's habit to meditate about the names we call things when relaxing in the bathtub or lying in bed at night. He sometimes will search for months in this way for just the right name for something. Such was his search for a replacement for "frozen star"/"collapsed star." Finally, in late 1967, he found the perfect name.

In typical Wheeler style, he did not go to his colleagues and say, "I've got a great new name for these things; let's call them da-de-da-de-da." Rather, he simply started to use the name as though no other name had ever existed, as though everyone had already agreed that this was the right name. He tried it out at a conference on pulsars in New York City in the late fall of 1967, and he then firmly adopted it in a lecture in December 1967 to the American Association for the Advancement of Science, entitled "Our Universe, the Known and the Unknown." Those of us not there encountered it first in the written version of his lecture: "[B]y reason of its faster and faster infall [the surface of the imploding star] moves away from the [distant] observer more and more rapidly. The light is shifted to the red. It becomes dimmer millisecond by millisecond, and in less than a second is too dark to see . . . [The star,] like the Cheshire cat, fades from view. One leaves behind only its grin, the other, only its gravitational attraction. Gravitational attraction, yes; light, no. No more than light do any particles emerge. Moreover, light and particles incident from outside ... [and] going down the black hole only add to its mass and increase its gravitational attraction."

Black hole was Wheeler's new name. Within months it was adopted enthusiastically by relativity physicists, astrophysicists, and the general public, in East as well as West—with one exception: In France, where the phrase *trou noir* (black hole) has obscene connotations, there was resistance for several years.